

Meeting 5: Midpoint Progress Check

Where each project stands and what A6 needs to show
Bachelor Project 2025–2026

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Thursday 21 May 2026
Regular slot

Today's Agenda

1. We are at the midpoint
2. Patterns across the group
3. Walking through each project
4. Your questions, in the room
5. What A6 looks like

Today is lighter on lecture and heavier on your questions. Bring them.

We are at the midpoint

Five meetings done, four to go. The first half was design. The second half is execution.

Behind you

- RQ and sub-questions stable
- C1, C2, C3 written
- Privacy checklists signed
- Datasets, instruments, dictionaries identified

Ahead of you

- Data construction or collection underway
- C4 first draft due Tuesday 26 May, 11:00
- Conference (A8) on 11 June
- Manuscript on 16 June

Important

From A6 onwards I grade more like the final thesis: description vs. analysis, evidence read through your C2, formal quality. Pick the simpler version of your design and execute it.

Patterns across the group

In place

- Operationalisation tables for most projects
- Datasets named
- Hypotheses committed to a direction
- Conceptual models drawn

Common gaps for A6

- First empirical output not yet produced
- RQ and hypothesis wording still drifts between chapters
- C2+C3 already eating the word budget; C4 needs the room
- Cover sheet word counts missing

Word-count rule of thumb: C1 500–800, C2 2000–2500, C3 500–1000, C4 3500–4000, C5 800–1300. Hard cap 10,000. Several of you are already at 4–5.5k with C4 still to come.

How the next 2h45 will run

Two groups of four, about 20 minutes per person, with a short break between groups:

1. I name where you are and the one thing to settle for A6.
2. Your cross-feedback partner opens with one execution question.
3. We open it to the room.
4. You leave with one commitment for A6 (Tuesday 26 May, 11:00).

A6 deliverable = first empirical output (*even partial*) + stated word count

Four working meetings remain after today. Ask the questions you have.

Group A

Text-as-data and cross-national designs

Cross-feedback pairs: Kate ↔ Lea Kseniya ↔ Daniel

Kate Domnikoff: GDPR fines and textual complexity

Where you are: Methodology in prose. Robb taxonomy in C2. Meta as running example. Halstead operationalisation in 2.3.

$$\text{Fine amount (CMS)} = \text{effect} \times \text{Halstead complexity of cited article(s)} + (\text{firm size, sector})$$

Discuss with Lea, then with the room:

- **Run Halstead on three articles** before A6 (short, medium, long). Confirm the index discriminates. Better to find that out at A6 than at A8.
- **Decide GDPR-only or GDPR+DMA** and align RQ, title page, and methodology. GDPR-only is fine; pick.
- **Multi-article fines:** assign to the primary cited article or split across articles. Either is defensible; justify in two sentences.
- **Editor queries:** two highlighted comments still open. Resolve before A6.

Lea Géciová: digital sovereignty and internet freedom (OECD)

Where you are: Protective/oppressive labelling applied across the model. Cronbach diagnostics run. 4,563 words.

$$\text{Internet freedom} = \beta_1 \times \text{Protective DS} + \beta_2 \times \text{Oppressive DS} + \text{moderation by libdem}$$

Three tables for C4: protective, oppressive, combined. Moderation on top of the main specifications.

Discuss with Kate, then with the room:

- **Drop protect_sov** ($\alpha = 0.177$). Switch to Plan B (v2privcon, v2smlawpr, v2smregon, $\alpha \approx 0.6$). 0.6 is acceptable on a novel composite; 0.17 is not. Update the op table, the model figure, and section 3.
- **Include the four late OECD joiners** with footnote on accession year; report N by country-year in appendix.
- **A6 deliverable:** merged panel as a file, one-page descriptives, first OLS with country and year FE, SEs clustered by country. If the sign on the main effect is wrong, come to me before adding moderation.

Kseniya Sidorenko: digital mobilisation and sentencing (RU)

Where you are: Analytical dataset built (2,911 cases). Telegram corpus complete (86 channels, 2018–2025). Mobilisation matched at prisoner level. Eight-category severity scale from Articles 44 and 15.

$$\text{Sentence severity (0–7)} = \beta_1 \times \text{Visibility} + \beta_2 \times \text{Post-Feb 2022} + \beta_3 \times \text{Visibility} \times \text{Post-Feb 2022} + \text{controls}$$

Discuss with Daniel, then with the room:

- **Consolidate the seven descriptive tables into one.** N, mean, SD, median, min, max for continuous; N + % for categoricals. Keep the pre/post-cut severity crosstab as the second table (it previews the finding).
- **Log-transform mobilisation:** mean 0.000034, max 0.0040 justifies it. Note in prose.
- **Article 282.2 robustness:** confirm enough cases on both sides of 21 Feb 2022 *before* A6; otherwise pool the top three or four articles.
- **A6 deliverable:** first ordered-logit estimated with one or two controls plus the interaction. Predicted-probability plot if time allows.

Daniel Ugarte: digital repression and backsliding (HU)

Where you are: Dictionary table filled in. Four categories, 4–5 Hungarian terms each, tied to Earl / Feldstein / Roberts / Schumann / Varol.

$$\text{H1: } V\text{-Dem}_t = \beta \times \text{Restrictive laws}_{t-k}$$

$$\text{H2: } \text{Restrictiveness}_{\text{law}} = \beta \times \text{Year passed}$$

Discuss with Kseniya, then with the room:

- **Housekeeping to land by Tuesday:** updated cover date and word count; RQ split into one main + two sub-questions; H1 tightened; corpus size in C3.
- **A6 deliverable:** dictionary applied end to end to the 2020 Scaremongering Amendment. Counts per category, example sentence per category, one paragraph on over/under-firing.
- **Decide:** are unmatched sentences a fifth neutral category, or excluded from the restrictiveness score? One sentence in C3.

Group B

Case, applied, and mixed designs

Cross-feedback pairs: Anand ↔ Vince Francis ↔ Louiza

Anand Dev Esponda: TikTok ownership and Gen Z media trust (NL)

Where you are: Methodology in prose. Survey built end to end. DV switched from “trust in US politics” to “media trust”. Ethics covers informed consent, anonymisation, retention.

$$\text{Media trust (Dutch Gen Z)} = \text{effect} \times \text{Perceived foreign ownership of TikTok} + \text{(controls)}$$

Discuss with Vince, then with the room:

- **Alignment:** carry “media trust” through C1, C2, and the hypothesis. Clean directional claim: “higher perceived foreign ownership of TikTok is associated with lower media trust among Dutch Gen Z”.
- **Instrument before piloting:** convert the Algorithmic Spillover block to 5-point Likert; split double-barreled items; add an item on awareness of the TikTok ownership change.
- **Algorithmic Spillover subsection** in C2: write it out or drop the mechanism. Tag the remaining (SOURCE) placeholders in C1.
- **A6 deliverable:** survey live, instrument fixes applied, $\approx$ 30 responses in hand.

Vince Kromberg: ToS clauses and regulatory shocks

Where you are: Three-stage pipeline: segmentation, classification, rubric scoring. Two appendix docs (Classification, Directionality). 5 time points $\times$ 4 platforms = 20 platform-years.

ToS clause direction (+1 / 0 / -1) measured at 5 time points across Upwork, Fiverr, AMT, Freelancer, on fee and termination clauses

Discuss with Anand, then with the room:

- **Complete the RQ sentence** in 1.2 and align it with the two hypotheses.
- **Frame as descriptive, not inferential.** 20 platform-years is not enough power for “clustering” as a statistical claim. Read it as visible directional shift.
- **Pull every snapshot** from Wayback / ToS;DR this week. Small table of snapshot dates and word counts on Tuesday.
- **Dictionary noise:** constrain numeric keywords (10%, 15%) to appear near a fee word, or drop. Tighten “withdrawal” to “withdrawal fee”.
- **A6 deliverable:** one platform’s 3–4 snapshots segmented, classified, scored; small table of triggered terms with one example sentence per category.

Francis van Luyn: Digital Silk Road and ASEAN sovereignty

Where you are: Datasets named: AidData v3.0, V-Dem DSP v8, V-Dem main v15. Controls: libdem or polyarchy, GDP per capita, internet penetration. DV components listed; v2smprivcon flagged for reversal.

$$\text{Digital sovereignty (DSP)}_t = \text{effect} \times \text{Chinese-built infrastructure (AidData)}_{t-5} + \text{controls}$$

Country-year panel, ASEAN-10, X window 2008–2018, Y to 2023. N ≈ 100–130 before missing.

Four decisions to commit to before A6:

- **Commit to a panel design**, not cross-sectional.
- **Name the estimator:** OLS with country and year FE, SEs clustered by country. One sentence in section 3.
- **AidData filter:** OECD-DAC 22020 + 22030 (and v3.0 data-centre tags). Disbursements, not commitments. Justify in one paragraph; commitment as robustness.
- **Lock the time window:** 2008–2018 with five-year build-out lag.

A6 deliverable: merged country-year file, one-page descriptives, first OLS with FE and clustered SEs.

Louiza Reysen: digital accessibility of German municipal websites

Where you are: C2 on the digital divide in prose (van Dijk, DiMaggio, Wei et al.). Estonia contrast used to frame the gap.

$$\text{Lighthouse Accessibility (0–100)} = \beta_1 \times \text{Size} + \beta_2 \times \frac{\text{Years in office}}{\text{date}} + \beta_3 \times \text{Website creation}$$

Bring written, today:

- **One-sentence decision on federal vs. municipal scope**, IVs adjusted accordingly.
- **Final sample size and frame**, one paragraph on how you draw the sample (200, not 500).
- **H1 reformulated** as a clear directional prediction.

Audit: Lighthouse via PageSpeed Insights API or Lighthouse CI. WAVE/Axe on 5–10 sites as validation.

IV recode: switch the 1–4 political-affiliation scale to *years in office* (current mayor or current coalition). Party-family as separate IV if wanted.

Discussion

The reason today is a check-in: there are questions you have been holding. Now is the time.

1. **One thing that is blocking you** this week that I or the room can unblock in five minutes.
2. **One thing that is going better than you expected**, that the rest of the group should hear about.
3. **One question about C4** (the empirical chapter) that you do not yet know the answer to.

“How do I run X” and “what does Y mean” are both fair.

Questions I expect (and short answers)

- **“How do I know if my first regression is enough?”** One specification with the headline IV, country and year FE, two or three sensible controls, clustered SEs. That is the bachelor-level baseline. Robustness on top.
- **“Cronbach below 0.7 — panic?”** Around 0.6 on a novel composite is acceptable with a sentence in limitations. Below 0.4 means the items are not measuring one construct; switch.
- **“How many interviews / responses do I need?”** The thresholds in the supervisor manual (10 interviews, 80 survey respondents, etc.) are the floor, not the target. Aim above.
- **“Can I add another control / hypothesis / mechanism?”** Almost always no. Execute what is on the table. Robustness, not new specifications.
- **“ChatGPT for X?”** For code scaffolding, fine. For interpretation, no. Disclose any AI use in the methods chapter.

What A6 looks like (Tuesday 26 May, 11:00 on Canvas)

A6 is the C4 first draft. What I want is the first empirical output, even partial. Per project:

Kate	Halstead on three articles + matched fines
Lea	Merged panel; first OLS with country/year FE; clustered SEs
Kseniya	First ordered logit estimated; consolidated descriptives table
Daniel	Dictionary applied end-to-end on the 2020 Scaremongering Amendment
Anand	Survey live; instrument fixes applied; ≈ 30 responses
Vince	At least one platform's snapshots segmented, classified, scored
Francis	Merged ASEAN-10 file; first OLS with country/year FE
Louiza	Design locked (3 items above); first Lighthouse audits running

Reminders for everyone: stated word count on the cover; description vs. analysis; a clean simple spec done carefully beats an ambitious one half-finished.

Calendar from here

Date	Deadline	What it is
Tue 26 May	A6, 11:00	C4 first draft (first empirical output)
Thu 28 May	Meeting 6	Description vs. analysis; coding tree quality
Tue 2 Jun	A7, 11:00	C4 revised + C5 draft
Thu 4 Jun	Meeting 7	Answering RQ; scientific vs. policy recommendations
Thu 11 Jun	A8, conference	Presentations graded at EUC
Tue 16 Jun	A9, 11:00	Draft manuscript
Thu 18 Jun	Meeting 9	1:1 consultations on the draft
Thu 25 Jun	Final	Thesis submission

Four working meetings remain after today.

Key References

Execution at bachelor level:

- Angrist, J.D. & Pischke, J.-S. (2009). *Mostly Harmless Econometrics*, Ch. 5 (panel and clustered SE basics). Princeton UP.
- Field, A. (2018). *Discovering Statistics Using IBM SPSS*. 5th ed. Sage. (Chapters on multiple regression and logistic regression.)

Qualitative analysis:

- Braun, V. & Clarke, V. (2006). Using thematic analysis in psychology. *Qualitative Research in Psychology*, 3(2), 77–101.
- Saldaña, J. (2016). *The Coding Manual for Qualitative Researchers*. 3rd ed. Sage.

Methods walkthroughs on the course site (same password):

- OLS regression in R; panel data with fixed effects in R; NLP pipeline in Python.

Questions?

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